

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Kingship

Israel wanted a king to be “like all the other nations.” By the time of Saul and David, kingship in the ancient Near East was nearly two thousand years old. This was especially true in the Egyptian and Babylonian empires. Even smaller nations like Philistia, Moab, and Edom had kings with permanent governments and armies. People believed kings were chosen by the gods to rule human affairs. Kings ruled either for the gods or as gods themselves.

The Israelites wanted to be like other nations and ignored the long-term effects of having a king, despite the prophet Samuel’s warnings ([1 Samuel 8:10–18](#)). Over several hundred years, having kings proved Samuel right. Bad kings led God’s chosen people into foreign control and exile. Yet, God used the monarchy to achieve his plans, as he provided the Messiah (God’s chosen one) through David and his family line, creating an eternal kingdom (see [2 Samuel 7:8–16](#); [Matthew 21:1–11](#); [Revelation 5:5](#); [11:15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 17:14–20](#); [33:5](#); [Judges 17:6](#); [21:25](#);
[1 Samuel 8:5–22](#); [10:1](#), [24–25](#); [2 Samuel 7:8–16](#);
[Psalm 89:35–37](#); [Ecclesiastes 8:2–5](#); [Isaiah 33:22](#);
[Matthew 21:1–11](#); [22:42–46](#); [27:11](#); [1 Timothy 1:17](#);
[1 Peter 2:13–14](#); [Revelation 5:5](#); [11:15](#); [15:3](#)

Knowing God

To know someone meant having a close relationship with them. Knowing God involves more than just learning facts about him. It goes beyond discussing God’s nature and character, though those things are important.

Knowing God means forming a close relationship with him. It involves seeing things as God does and learning to imitate him. Knowing God changes our thoughts, actions, priorities, values, and relationships with others. It is more important than religious ceremonies, sacrifices, or any other religious activities (see [Jeremiah 9:23–24](#); [31:34](#)).

The prophet Hosea emphasizes the importance of knowing God. He shows that God would destroy Israel because they did not know God ([Hosea 4:1,6](#)).

This theme is also common in the New Testament Gospel of John. Jesus often emphasizes the need to know God. He affirms that people can engage in religious practices but lack a true relationship with God (see [John 7:25–29](#); [8:14–19](#), [54–55](#); [14:6–11](#); [17:1–3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 33:8](#), [11](#); [Numbers 12:6–8](#); [Isaiah 11:9](#); [43:10](#);
[Jeremiah 9:24](#); [31:33–34](#); [Hosea 6:3](#), [6](#); [John 17:3](#);
[Philippians 3:10](#); [Titus 1:16](#); [Hebrews 8:10–13](#); [1 John 2:4](#);
[4:6](#), [8](#); [3 John 1:11](#)